

Strengthening the Prevention and Response to Sexual and Gender-Based Violence in Kwale County

Executive Summary

Sexual and Gender-Based Violence (SGBV) remains a major public health, human rights and development challenge that disproportionately affects women, girls and other vulnerable populations. Recognizing the need for a coordinated response, Kwale County enacted the Kwale County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence Act, 2024, becoming one of the first counties in Kenya with a legislative framework to prevent, respond and remedying to SGBV. The Act establishes comprehensive legal framework for prevention, defines protective services, ensures survivor support services, promotes prosecution of perpetrators and improving coordination among government agencies and partners.

The enactment of the Act represents an important milestone. However, legislation alone cannot produce survivors’ relief. Act for implementation. Progress has been limited by inadequate survivor services, limited safe houses, weak coordination mechanisms, insufficient financing and low public awareness of the rights and services provided under the Act.

This infographic is a call for Kwale County to translate its fully capacitated the Kwale County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence Act, 2024 by investing in survivor-centred services, strengthening county coordination, increasing budget allocations and improving community awareness.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Every survivor deserves safety, dignity and justice. A fully operational SGBV response system saves lives, restores hope and strengthens communities.

Investing in prevention and survivor-centred services is not just a legal obligation – it is a moral commitment to equality, human rights and inclusive development in Kwale County.

County Legal & Policy Landscape

Kwale County has established a strong legal foundation for addressing sexual and gender-based violence. The policy now is to ensure that these commitments translate into effective services for survivors.

County Framework	Status	Key Provisions	Current Position
Kwale County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence Act, 2024	Enacted	Prohibits sexual and gender-based violence; prevention of SGBV; multi-agency response services, professional standards, protection of perpetrators, and national coordination and accountability.	Implementation has commenced but remains at an early stage, with significant gaps including financing investment and strengthening.
Draft Kwale County Gender and Sexual Inclusion Policy	Pending adoption	Promotes gender equality, inclusive service delivery, gender mainstreaming approaches and resources, and stakeholder participation across county services.	Draft policy awaiting finalization and adoption to strengthen inclusion, gender and inclusion programming.

Current Implementation Gaps

Despite the enactment of the SGBV Act, several barriers continue to limit effective implementation.

- Inadequate Gender-Based Violence Recovery Centres (GBVRCs) across the county.
- Limited availability of safe houses and temporary shelters for survivors.
- Weak coordination across health, police, NGOs, legal and community actors.
- Limited public awareness of the rights, protections and services established under the Act.
- Inadequate county budget allocation for implementation.
- Delays in adopting the Gender and Gender Inclusion Policy.
- Limited survivors get effective systems for reporting services.
- Capacity gaps among frontline service providers in delivering coordinated survivor-centred care.

Priority Advocacy Actions

Priority Area	Lead Institution	Recommended Advocacy Actions	Expected Outcome
Strengthen Survivor-Centred Services	Department of Health, Department of Gender	Establish and adequately equip additional Gender-Based Violence Recovery Centres (GBVRCs) in strengthen referral systems and expand psychosocial support services across the county.	Survivors receive timely, comprehensive and quality care closer to their communities.
Expand Safe Houses and Protection Services	Department of Gender, County Treasury, Development Partners	Increase the number of safe houses and emergency shelters for survivors of violence and strengthen reintegration services.	Improved protection and safety for survivors at immediate risk.
Increase County Financing	County Treasury, County Assembly	Create dedicated budget lines for implementation of the Kwale County SGBV Act, including survivor services, prevention programmes, community awareness and coordination mechanisms.	Sustainable financing for county-wide implementation.
Strengthen Multi-sectoral Coordination	Department of Gender, Gender Technical Working Group, CMAT	Operationalise county coordination structures involving health, police, judiciary, education, social services, civil society and community representatives.	Improved coordination and more efficient referral pathways.
Strengthen Community Awareness and Prevention	Department of Gender, Community Health Services, CCMI, Faith Leaders	Conduct countywide awareness campaigns on SGBV, prevention, survivor rights, reporting mechanisms and services available under the Act. Address harmful gender norms and social stigma.	Increased reporting of SGBV cases and stronger community support for survivors.
Build Capacity of Frontline Service Providers	Department of Health, Judiciary, National Police Service, Department of Gender	Train healthcare workers, police officers, social workers, legal officers and Community Health Promoters on survivor-centred care, referral pathways, case identification protocols and implementation of the SGBV Act.	Improved quality, consistency and responsiveness of county services.
Finalise the Gender and Social Inclusion Policy	Department of Gender, County Executive, County Assembly	Fast-track review, approval and adoption of the Draft Gender and Social Inclusion Policy to strengthen inclusive prevention and response strategies.	A comprehensive policy framework supporting implementation of the SGBV Act.
Strengthen Monitoring and Accountability	Department of Gender, Monitoring & Evaluation Unit	Develop county implementation indicators, conduct annual implementation reviews and strengthen routine reporting on survivor services and prevention programmes.	Improved accountability and evidence-based decision-making.

County Implementation Scorecard

Implementation Area	Current Status	Priority Action
Kwale County SGBV Act	Enacted	Accelerate county-wide implementation.
Gender & Social Inclusion Policy	Pending adoption	Finalise and adopt the policy.
Gender-Based Violence Recovery Centres	Moderate	Expand and strengthen survivor services.
Safe Houses	Low	Increase the number of safe shelters across the county.
County Budget Allocation	Low	Establish dedicated implementation budget lines.
Multi-sectoral Coordination	Moderate	Strengthen coordination and referral systems.
Community Awareness	Low	Scale up prevention and awareness campaigns.
Monitoring & Accountability	Low	Develop implementation indicators and routine reporting mechanisms.

County Implementation Roadmap

Priority Action	Lead Institution	Timeline
Operationalise the Kwale County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence Act across all county departments.	Department of Gender	Immediate (1–6 months)
Finalise and adopt the Draft Gender and Social Inclusion Policy.	Department of Gender, County Executive	0–6 months
Establish dedicated county budget lines for implementation of the Act.	County Treasury, County Assembly	Annual Budgeting Cycle
Expand GBV Recovery Centres and survivor referral services.	Department of Health	6–18 months
Increase safe houses and emergency protection services.	Department of Gender	6–18 months
Roll out county-wide capacity building programmes for frontline service providers.	Department of Health, Department of Gender	Continuous
Conduct county-wide SGBV prevention and community awareness campaigns.	Department of Gender, Community Health Services, CCMI	Continuous

Conduct annual implementation reviews and publish county progress reports.	Department of Gender, Monitoring & Evaluation Unit	Annual
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Kwale County has already demonstrated leadership by enacting the Kwale County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence Act, 2024. The priority now is to ensure that every survivor benefits from the protections and services envisioned by the law.